



A Lar holding  
a goat-headed  
drinking horn

Agathodaimon,  
a protective  
spirit in the  
form of a snake

#### ▲ Household spirit

This altar from a house in Pompeii shows the *genius* (presiding deity) of the household making a sacrifice to the Lares, protective ancestral spirits who kept their domain safe from the *larvae* (malicious ghosts).

Astrology straddled the divide between popular and aristocratic magic. Nigidius Figulus, a prominent scholar and friend of the statesman Cicero, wrote a book on Egyptian astrology, which was at the root of many Roman practices. Even the eminent astronomer Claudius Ptolemy (whose theory of planetary spheres and an Earth-centered solar system would last until the Renaissance) pointed out that

just as the tides were affected by the moon, so the motion of the planets would, intuitively, influence the behavior of men.

Surviving Roman horoscopes include few actual predictions, but astrologers did provide them. They were based on a belief that the soul, in descending to Earth for its birth, acquired certain traits from the planetary spheres such as cunning from Saturn;